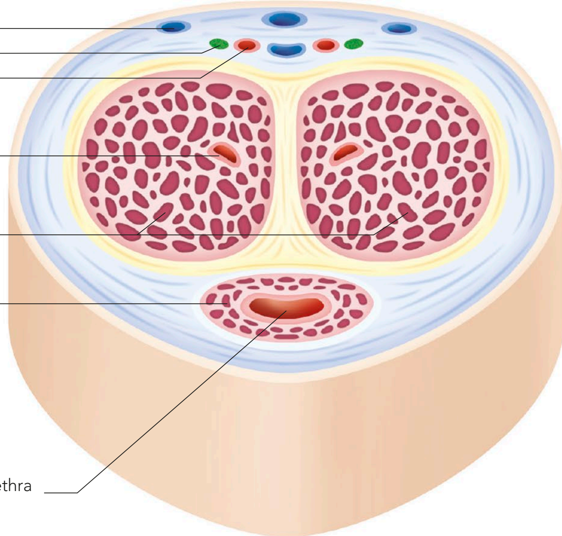
PATHWAY FOR SPERM

During ejaculation, waves of muscle contraction squeeze the sperm in their fluid from the epididymis along the vas deferens. This tube is joined by a duct from the seminal vesicle to form the ejaculatory duct. The left and right ejaculatory ducts join the urethra within the prostate gland.

In the male, the urethra is a dual-purpose tube that carries urine from the bladder during urination and sperm from the testes. During ejaculation, however, the sphincter at the base of the bladder is closed because of high pressure in the urethra, preventing the passage of urine.

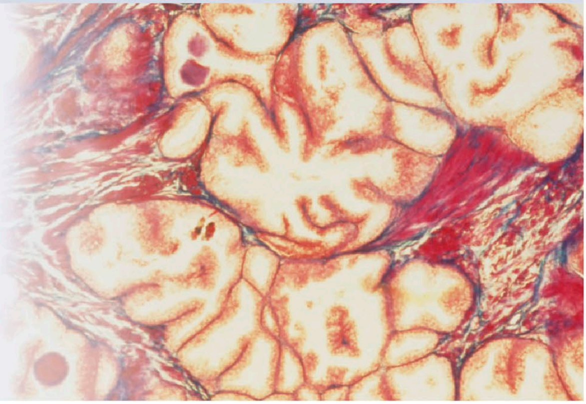


PENILE ERECTION

During arousal, large quantities of arterial blood enter the corpus spongiosum and corpus cavernosum, compressing the veins. As a result, blood cannot drain from the penis and it becomes hard and erect.

SEMEN

Seminal fluid, or semen, is sperm mixed with fluid added by the accessory glands (see opposite), including the prostate gland. The prostate secretes fluid through tiny ducts to mix with sperm as they are ejaculated down the urethra. The final mix has around 300–500 million sperm in 2–5ml ($^{1}/_{15}$–$^{1}/_{6}$ fl oz) of fluid.



PROSTATE GLAND

This microscopic view of a section of prostate gland tissue shows a number of secretory ducts (orange and white).